nirpeksh. This is why this word should be debated seriously. Secondly, what is the meaning of secularism in the country? If panth-nirpekshta is secularism, then nobody is a bigger secular than the Hindu who speaks of "*Sarve bhavantu sukhinah*" [May all be happy], "*Vasudhaiva kutumbakam*" [The world is one family], "*Ekam satya vipra bahudha vadanti*" [There is only one truth (or true being) and learned persons call it by many names]. But in this country, what have so-called secularists turned the meaning of secularism into? Those who abuse Indianness, those who oppose sanaatan tradition, those who abuse Indian greats—they will be great secularists. We don't need this kind of secularism in this country … Secularism must mean *sarv panth samabhaav* [equal respect for all sects]. No government or state can run by taking any one upasna vidhi [worship system] alone. It must respect all. In this matter, you will see that our government respects *sarv panth samabhaav* and its spirit.'[8]

Hindu Counter-mobilisation in UP and the Hindi Heartland's Muslim-significant Seats

Electorally, much has been made of the symbolism of the BJP's decision from 2014 onwards of not fielding a single Muslim candidate in any UP national or state election. Its critics interpreted this policy as a signal to Muslim voters that they do not impact its fortunes. In a state where one in every five voters is Muslim, such a strategy would once have been political suicide. Yet, the BJP has won election after election with it. The fact is that the BJP in UP specifically, and in the Hindi heartland more generally, has been winning a large number of seats with significantly high Muslim populations, ranging from Kairana, Muzaffarnagar and Meerut in western UP to Bareilly in central UP and Bahraich in the eastern part of the state. Just as it did with rural seats, the party, between 2014 and 2019, cemented itself as the dominant pole of politics in these seats. This is not because it won greater Muslim support, but because of Hindu counter-mobilisation in these areas. What often happens in many such constituencies is that rival parties tend to field Muslim candidates, while the BJP fields a Hindu candidate who then benefits from a consolidation of the Hindu vote.